

Case Discussion — Student Questions

Session 6 · *D&G's Marketing Missteps in China* (Hung & Ho, 2019)

Prepare these questions before class — we will discuss them in groups.

International Summer University^{WU} 2026 · **Dr. Arne Floh**, WU Vienna

Before class — read and watch

Come prepared: read the case and the two short HBR articles, and watch the campaign videos. Files are in the course folder.

READ · THE CASE

Hung & Ho (2019), *D&G's Marketing Missteps in China (A)* · [case-dg-china-marketing-missteps.pdf](#)

READ · TOOLKIT 1

Molinsky (2013), “Preparing for Inevitable Cultural Faux Pas,” *HBR* · [molinsky-2013-preparing-for-cultural-faux-pas.pdf](#)

READ · TOOLKIT 2

Hahn & Molinsky (2018), “How to Recover from a Cultural Faux Pas,” *HBR* · [hahn-molinsky-2018-recover-from-cultural-faux-pas.pdf](#)

WATCH · THE CAMPAIGN

“Eating with Chopsticks” — the three episodes · <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TBFC5isQuYA>

WATCH · THE CONTRAST

#DGLovesJapan — the campaign that worked (search the title if the link has moved) · <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bJXq3EVzd9g>

Videos are third-party re-uploads (D&G removed the originals). If a link has moved, search the titles.

How we will work with these questions

- Prepare **brief notes** on all four questions before class — a few bullet points each is enough.
- In class we discuss them **in the order below**, in small groups, then share with the room.
- Bring **evidence from the case** (and your own examples) — not just opinions.
- Use the **frameworks** from our sessions: culture (Hall, Hofstede, Meyer), the three Ms, crisis management and SCCT.
- There are **no single right answers** — you are graded on the quality of your reasoning.

Be ready to **take and defend a position** — especially on whether the Shanghai show should have gone ahead.

Why did the campaign offend?

DISCUSSION QUESTION 1

- What were the intended “**jokes**” in the three videos?
- Why did most Chinese — and many other — viewers receive them so **negatively**?
- Which specific **cultural cues** were misread, and why do they matter?
- Could the same idea have been advertised in a **better, more effective** way?

Prepare with: the case narrative; the culture session (Hall, Hofstede, Meyer); the idea of high- vs. low-context cultures.

Humour and the brand

DISCUSSION QUESTION 2

- How does **humour** fit — or clash with — D&G’s luxury **brand image**?
- What are the **advantages** of humorous appeals in advertising?
- What are the **risks**, especially when an ad crosses cultures?
- How would you “**turn it around**” to get the intended humorous effect?

Prepare with: the three Ms of offensiveness (matter, media, manner); the #DGLovesJapan contrast.

Crisis communication

DISCUSSION QUESTION 3

- How **effective** was D&G's crisis response — what did it do, and fail to do?
- What **should** it have done, and how **quickly**?
- How should **social media** change the way a company responds?
- How could D&G **prevent a recurrence** in China and other markets?

Prepare with: the three phases of crisis management; “stealing thunder”; attribution theory / SCCT.

Repairing and rebuilding in China

DISCUSSION QUESTION 4

- How can D&G repair the **immediate** reputational damage?
- How can it rebuild its **long-term image** in China?
- **Who** should be involved — local teams, agencies, partners, government?
- What would signal **genuine change** rather than a quick PR patch?

Prepare with: the reputation-repair strategies; the two HBR readings on preparing for and recovering from faux pas.

Take it further — your own market entry

- Look at your **market-entry group assignment**: where could your MNE make a **cultural misstep** in its target market?
- Name **one realistic faux pas** — in advertising, product, or management — and how the local audience might read it.
- Add **two safeguards** (e.g. local review, testing, empowered local staff) to your **risk-management analysis**.

The D&G case is a warning; your job is to design the entry so it does **not** become your case.



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Case: Hung, K. & Ho, M. (2019). D&G's Marketing Missteps in China. Asia Case Research Centre, HKU.